Who can challenge, correct and decide?

What our computer-checked examples show
Progress report | November 1, 2026

The finding

Our computer-checked examples separate a named officer, an appeal, correction power, timely control, independent oversight and community participation. These safeguards need separate evidence. A board can miss decisions outside its remit, and community input can matter without giving the community final control. Each example states its rules and limits.

A simple employment example

Imagine that an AI-assisted hiring decision rejects an applicant and causes harm. A named officer is responsible. The applicant can send an appeal to a desk that can reconsider the decision. In the first version, that desk has no power to correct it. In the second version, we give the desk correction power. Everything else in the example stays the same.

This is a hypothetical case. We have not investigated a real employer or measured harm to actual applicants.

Safeguard in our example	First version	Changed version
Named responsible officer	Yes	Yes
Explanation and human review	Yes	Yes
Accessible appeal	Yes	Yes
Power to correct	No	Yes
Meets responsibility-and-appeal checklist	Yes	Yes
Meets checklist also requiring correction capacity	No	Yes

Why this matters

When assessing an AI appeal process, ask two separate questions: Can the person get a review? Can someone correct the decision if that review finds an error? A positive answer to the first question does not supply the second.

These are hypothetical, small models. Lean checks consequences of our rules, not whether our source interpretation is uniquely correct or an actual institution complies. A written duty does not establish that its safeguard is provided.

Source: official English Vatican text, Magnifica Humanitas, selected paragraphs 97-111. Accessed November 1, 2026. Read the source. Evidence and assumptions: docs/TECHNICAL_RESULTS.md and project verification logs.

Having a voice and having the last word

A community can contribute, amend its recommendation and influence an outcome while the institution keeps final control.

The example

A community contributes to review of our hypothetical benefit denial. Its recommendation is accepted and recorded. It can amend that record from 'deny' to 'grant.' When the institution does not override, that amendment changes the result. If it does override, the institution can choose either result regardless of the recommendation.

Check in the review procedure	Central rule	Binding local rule
Input accepted, recorded and amendable?	Yes	Yes
Input can change result without an override?	Yes	Yes
Institution can override the recommendation?	Yes	No
Community can impose either final outcome?	No	Yes

Both versions retain the original denial's named responsibility, appeal, correction capacity and the previously tested oversight condition. They change only the final rule of this review procedure.

What Lean checked

The central version has real input and a demonstrated influence on the outcome, yet no local final control or absolute veto over a grant. In the comparison, the recorded recommendation becomes binding. Acceptance, recording and amendment stay the same. The extra final-rule commitment supplies control; consultation alone does not.

The practical question

When told 'communities participate,' ask what they can change and when the institution can overrule them. Correcting a community's own recorded recommendation is different from correcting the final decision or changing the institution's standards.

Assumptions and limits

Recording and amendment are stipulated, not audited real-world facts. The example does not establish full subsidiarity, fairness or legitimate authority. Its interpretation of paragraphs 107-109 leaves broader powers open. Neither final rule is endorsed. Developer responsibility and governing authority are next.

Who owns this decision?

A named agency and a public contact do not necessarily identify the person assigned to your case.

The example

Imagine an AI-assisted public-benefit denial. The agency accepts responsibility, publishes a contact's name, and assigns every important decision internally. But the contact handles routine inquiries; another employee handles the denial. In the first version, that case officer is not identifiable. Known staffing and internal assignment therefore do not supply an identifiable case owner.

These are stipulated facts in a hypothetical office. We have not audited an actual public-benefits agency.

Question about the denial	Unnamed	Named only	Name + power
Agency and public contact identified?	Yes	Yes	Yes
An officer assigned to the denial?	Yes	Yes	Yes
That officer identifiable?	No	Yes	Yes
That officer has correction power?	Yes	No	Yes
Identifiable case owner with power?	No	No	Yes

What Lean checked

The first version has known staff and internal allocation, yet no identifiable assignee for the denial. The second names that assignee but supplies no correction power. The third provides both. The agency, membership, and assignments stay fixed.

We also checked a sufficient rule: assign the decision to a person and ensure that this person is identifiable. Correction capacity through that person needs a separate authority condition for the same decision.

The practical lesson

Ask who is assigned to this decision, whether that person is identifiable, and whether they can correct it. These are separate questions. A general contact list does not answer all three.

What this still does not establish

Authority does not prove that the officer will act, that the applicant can reach them, or that every loss can be undone. We have not established legal liability, a uniquely correct reading of the source, or major research novelty.

A stop that arrives too late

The same final checklist can hide a crucial difference: whether control reached the system before the harm occurred.

The example

We model a hazardous autonomous action. A stop request is sent, delivered, and followed by a corrected decision record. One run delivers the stop before execution; the other delivers it afterward. Both finish with the stop recorded as delivered and the administrative record corrected. Only the timely run avoids physical loss.

This is a hypothetical case with explicit rules. We assume a delivered stop is obeyed and that none of the five available actions can reverse the physical loss. Those assumptions are not discoveries about real systems.

Check	Timely run	Late run
Stop requested?	Yes	Yes
Stop delivered?	Before execution	After execution
Record corrected afterward?	Yes	Yes
Record-correction officer identifiable?	Yes	Yes
Physical loss in the model?	No	Yes

What Lean checked

The two runs contain the same four events; only the delivery and execution order changes. Lean checked the different outcomes. It also checked that once physical loss occurs, no finite sequence of the available actions removes it. Correcting the record remains possible, but it does not restore the physical outcome.

There is a positive result too: if the stop has already arrived while the state is loss-free, every continuation allowed by these rules stays loss-free. That is a conditional guarantee inside our model, not a proof that real operators always detect danger or respond in time.

The practical lesson

Ask when control became effective, not just whether a human was involved. Also ask what a promised correction can change: the record, the decision, or the physical harm. Those protections are different.

Where the limits matter

The result depends on the stated irreversibility and stop rules. It does not establish that every real loss is permanent or that the encyclical uniquely requires this particular mechanism. We have initial examples in all three agreed case domains; the full research project remains unfinished.

Who gets to appeal?

An internal review does not itself give the affected person an appeal. The duty's starting point matters.

Two explicit readings

The narrow reading requires appeal after exclusion. The broader reading keeps that rule and adds appeal for an affected person in a consequential decision, even before exclusion. These are two working interpretations; we do not claim they exhaust the source's possible readings.

Hypothetical situation	Narrow checklist	Broad checklist
Person excluded; no accessible appeal	Fails	Fails
Consequential decision affects person; no exclusion yet; no appeal	Passes	Fails
Person excluded; accessible appeal provided	Passes	Passes

Named responsibility and internal review stay fixed. 'Passes' means only this limited checklist; neither policy includes a remedy-capacity duty.

What survives both readings

Both reject exclusion without an accessible appeal. This is a checked consequence of the shared rule, not a new moral discovery. Staff review may occur internally while the person has no channel to challenge. After exclusion, that arrangement fails both checklists.

Where the readings differ

An AI-assisted ranking can affect opportunities before exclusion. Without appeal, the narrow checklist can pass and the broader one fails. Its extra guarantee comes from the added duty. Opening person access satisfies both appeal checklists while review and assignment stay fixed.

The practical question

When an organization says 'a human reviews our AI decisions,' ask whether the affected person can challenge, and when that opportunity begins. Review, person access, and the duty's trigger are separate issues.

Assumptions and limits

These are hypothetical employment-style cases. High impact and affectedness are stipulated; actual harm is not assumed. The broader duty is explicit. Appeal alone does not establish remedy capacity, restoration, or full source compliance. The remaining agreed research questions are still unfinished.

Does the board cover your decision?

An independent board can exist without being able to oversee a particular benefit denial.

The example

Return to our hypothetical public-benefits office. Internal staff review a denial. An independent board can review routine inquiries, but the denial falls outside its remit. The person still has a named officer, an appeal and correction capacity. Those safeguards do not give the board jurisdiction over the denial.

Check for the benefit denial	Outside remit	Review only	Remit + power
Independent board exists and can review?	Yes	Yes	Yes
Denial within the board's remit?	No	Yes	Yes
Board has intervention power for denial?	Yes	No	Yes
Meets our actionable-oversight test?	No	No	Yes

In the first version, intervention power alone cannot overcome the missing remit. Internal review and the person's appeal and correction access stay fixed across all three versions.

What Lean checked

The first version has a real oversight role for routine inquiries but no independent coverage of the denial. The second covers the denial but lacks intervention power. The third supplies both. Each missing provision can be repaired while the other safeguards stay fixed. Both narrow and broad appeal checklists pass throughout; the oversight gap remains separate.

The practical question

When told 'we have independent oversight,' ask which decisions it covers and what the reviewer can do about them. The existence of a board, the right to review and the power to intervene are separate checks.

Assumptions and limits

Independence and powers are stipulated in this hypothetical example. Our test checks capacity, not actual action, speed or successful correction. The source's call for effective oversight is broader: criteria and community participation also matter. This example does not settle those requirements or prove full source compliance. The exact board arrangement is our interpretation of paragraphs 106 and 108.